

I discovered he was a good listener too, though I was not sure if he was genuinely interested in what I had to say or if it was just a pretence. 'How did you then end up in this field, doing what you are doing?' I wanted to ask him, but checked myself.

I don't know why, but I instinctively took a liking to him. Lucky was right. The man was too polished to be a stockbroker, let alone an operator involved in dodgy deals. I had heard GB mention him a few times, but he never aroused enough curiosity in me to find out more about him. From the little I knew about him, his speciality was mid-caps.

It was late in the evening. Monk asked if he should call for some food. We finally settled for *bhel* from the vendor on the street below.

'Good stuff, you won't regret it,' Monk said.

He was right, except that it was a bit too spicy and made my eyes water.

Over *bhel* and masala tea, Monk came to the point.

'I understand you are pretty upset with Lucky, and I won't blame you for that. Not Lucky's fault, as you would have realized by now. I put him up to it. But that's the way this market works. If I hadn't poached your man, somebody else would have, sooner than later. Admit it, Lala, you were paying him a pittance for the kind of information he was giving you. But I am impressed by your resourcefulness in developing a contact like that,' Monk said.

Munching on *bhel*, he went on: 'What has happened has happened. But I would like to have you for a friend, Lala. Of course, it is up to you, whether you feel the same way. And I want to make good your loss. So I have a proposal for you.' He paused.

I nodded.

'Have you ever thought of having a broking card of your own, Lala?' Monk asked.

'To be honest, the thought has crossed my mind a few times. But I wonder if it is worth sinking in Rs 1 crore. Besides, there are other expenses too. You need an office, and then there is the cost of maintaining the office. Besides, I am doing well for myself without all those headaches. In short, I am happy in my present situation,' I said.

'Undoubtedly. But don't you want to grow in this profession and swim with the big fish in the deep seas?' Monk asked.

'Perhaps, but that also calls for a sizeable investment, which I am not so confident about making at this point,' I said. But I had a vague idea of what